PRODUCT FOCUS AUDIT

Turn AscndLabs into the operating system for affiliate programs

Decision report for the first five paying businesses. Based on a code review and live authenticated capture of the current product.

The decision	Do not delete the app. Reposition it. Keep the money movement, admin, identity, referral and product foundations; pause the AI, gamification and creator-marketplace layers; build multi-tenant affiliate-program workflows on top.

• Business goal: get five paying businesses successfully running affiliate programs before expanding the platform.

• Current product: an AI builder, AscndLabs referral program, creator product storefront, earnings/payouts workflow, Discord layer and administrator console.

• Gap: current referrals belong to one user tree and one global commission configuration. A customer business cannot yet own a program, set terms, approve affiliates, attribute sales, or view a program-level operating dashboard.

Bottom line: aim for an affiliate-program SaaS, not a marketplace and not an “all-in-one creator empire.”

1. What the current app says vs. what you need to sell

The product currently makes a logged-in person look like an AscndLabs creator or affiliate. Your buyer should instead feel: “I can launch, manage and pay my affiliates from here.” That is a different primary user, hierarchy and vocabulary.

Observed area	What it currently communicates	Fit for the 5-business goal
Dashboard	Daily bonus, empire score, gamified creator journey.	Low. Replace with program health and next actions.
Affiliate Army	A user promotes AscndLabs and earns recurring rewards.	Partial. Reframe as the affiliate portal inside a specific business program.
Sell Products	A creator lists and sells their own digital products.	Partial. Keep only if it becomes a business offer catalog or Stripe offer connection.
Earnings and Payouts	An affiliate sees commissions and requests payment.	High. Reuse as the affiliate financial portal, scoped to a program.
Admin Panel	Platform operator manages users and payouts.	High. Split into AscndLabs platform admin and business owner program admin.
AI Builder and Assistant	A generic creator productivity suite.	Low for MVP. Hide from the primary navigation.

2. Feature disposition: keep, pause, or rebuild

Decision	Existing capability	What to do now
KEEP / ADAPT	Authentication, profiles, roles, notifications	Make User the universal identity. Add Organization and Membership rather than making a separate account system.
KEEP / ADAPT	Earnings, payout, Stripe Connect code	Rename Earnings to Commission in the product language. Add organizationId, programId, affiliateId, conversionId and clear hold/reversal states.
KEEP / ADAPT	Referral code/link and signup attribution	Convert to Program + Affiliate Link + Attribution. Links must be owned by a business program, not globally by a User.
KEEP / ADAPT	Digital products and checkout	Keep as an optional offer catalog/payment-link integration, not as the product's main identity.
PAUSE / HIDE	Viral Hooks, Product Generator, Niche Launchpad, AI chat	Remove from the business-facing navigation. Later, revive as an affiliate asset generator if customers ask for it.
PAUSE / HIDE	Daily bonus, empire score, leaderboard, Discord role sync	These distract from B2B trust. Keep code dormant; do not spend more effort polishing it for MVP.
REBUILD	Single global commission config and two-tier referral tree	Commission rules belong to each Program. Start with one-tier percentage or fixed commission only.
REBUILD	Global platform admin user management	Create business workspace roles: Owner, Program Manager, Finance, Viewer.

3. The smallest sellable product

For five customers, build only the loop that proves the business value: a business creates a program, an affiliate receives a link, a purchase is attributed, commission becomes payable, and both parties can see the result.

Business onboarding

• Create workspace: business name, logo, currency, timezone and support email.

• Connect Stripe and choose one starting offer or payment link.

• Set commission: percentage or fixed amount, 30-day cookie, payout hold and minimum payout.

• Publish a program page with terms and an affiliate application form.

Business program console

• Program health: approved affiliates, clicks, conversions, revenue, payable commissions and pending issues.

• Affiliate management: invite, review application, approve/reject, deactivate, set a custom rate and message an affiliate.

• Creative library: approved links, coupon codes, swipe copy and downloadable assets.

• Conversions and commissions: source attribution, status, reversal/refund handling and export.

Affiliate portal

• Apply or accept an invite, complete payout onboarding and see disclosure guidance.

• Get unique link and optional code, browse approved assets, see clicks/conversions/commission status, request payout.

4. Architecture that reuses your current code

Your current backend already has the hard ingredients: user identity, product/payment records, referral attribution, commission-like earnings records, 30-day holds, Stripe Connect onboarding, payout requests, notifications and admin actions. The change is tenancy and ownership.

New model	Purpose	Maps from current code
Organization	One paying business workspace.	New. Owns programs, team members, offers and billing.
Membership	A user’s role in an organization.	Extends User role; do not overload global admin/user role.
Program	Terms, currency, commission defaults, attribution rules, status.	Replaces global COMMISSION_RATES and global referral behavior.
Offer	What affiliates promote: Stripe Product/Price, payment link or tracked external URL.	Adapts DigitalProduct.
Affiliate	A person approved into a Program with a unique link/code and payout state.	Separates affiliate membership from the user referral tree.
Attribution	Click/link/cookie/coupon evidence that connects a conversion to an affiliate.	New. This is the missing center of the product.
Conversion	Sale, refund, cancellation, subscription renewal or manual adjustment.	Adapts Stripe webhook and DigitalProduct payment events.
Commission	Amount, rate, status, hold, reversal and payout relation.	Rename/adapt Earnings; add organization/program/conversion scope.
Payout	Batch or affiliate payout record.	Adapt Payout; scope to program/business finance controls.

Important payment design choice

For the first five businesses, position the product as a SaaS platform: each business remains the merchant of record and receives customer payments directly. Stripe documents direct charges as the usual fit for SaaS platforms, while marketplace/destination-charge flows make the platform responsible for more of the funds flow, refunds and chargeback exposure. Use Stripe-hosted onboarding or embedded components to reduce build time.

5. Six-week path to five paying businesses

When	Build / sell focus	Proof before moving on
Week 0	Choose one vertical: coaches, info products, SaaS, agencies or ecommerce. Interview 10 owners and recruit 5 design partners.	At least 3 say they will pay for the stated workflow, not for “AI.”
Week 1	New positioning, sales page, business workspace, organization/membership model, program setup wizard.	A business can create one draft program in under 15 minutes.
Week 2	Affiliate application/invite, approval queue, link/code creation and asset library.	A business invites one affiliate and that affiliate can obtain a unique link.
Week 3	Stripe offer connection, attribution records and webhook-created conversions.	One test purchase produces a visible conversion tied to an affiliate.
Week 4	Commission ledger, holds, reversal/refund rules, affiliate earnings portal and CSV export.	A business can explain every commission and one affiliate can see payment status.
Week 5	Payout workflow, business dashboard, onboarding fixes and concierge launches.	First business is live with at least five affiliates invited.
Week 6	Launch remaining partners, collect objections, invoice the first five, remove friction.	Five businesses have paid and each has a defined activation milestone.

Commercial recommendation

• Sell a paid concierge launch, not self-serve software: setup, program design, Stripe connection, first affiliate imports and weekly operating support.

• Use a simple validation price that you can say aloud on calls, for example a setup fee plus a monthly platform fee. Confirm willingness to pay before locking exact pricing.

• Do not promise a network of affiliates. Sell the operating system for the business’s existing audience, customers, partners and creators first.

6. What not to build before customer six

• No multi-tier or sub-affiliate commissions. Your current code contains two-tier logic; it increases explanation, disputes and fraud risk before you have a proven core loop.

• No broad marketplace. Do not become merchant of record for customer sales unless that is deliberately your business model.

• No affiliate discovery network, AI campaign suite, Discord community, gamification or leaderboard as core scope.

• No “everything dashboard.” The business dashboard should answer: who is approved, what converted, what is payable and what needs action.

• No custom finance ledger beyond the commission states required to explain a payout. Export to CSV for the first five.

Non-negotiable trust requirements

• Every commission needs an auditable source: affiliate, link/code, offer, conversion, rate, status and adjustment history.

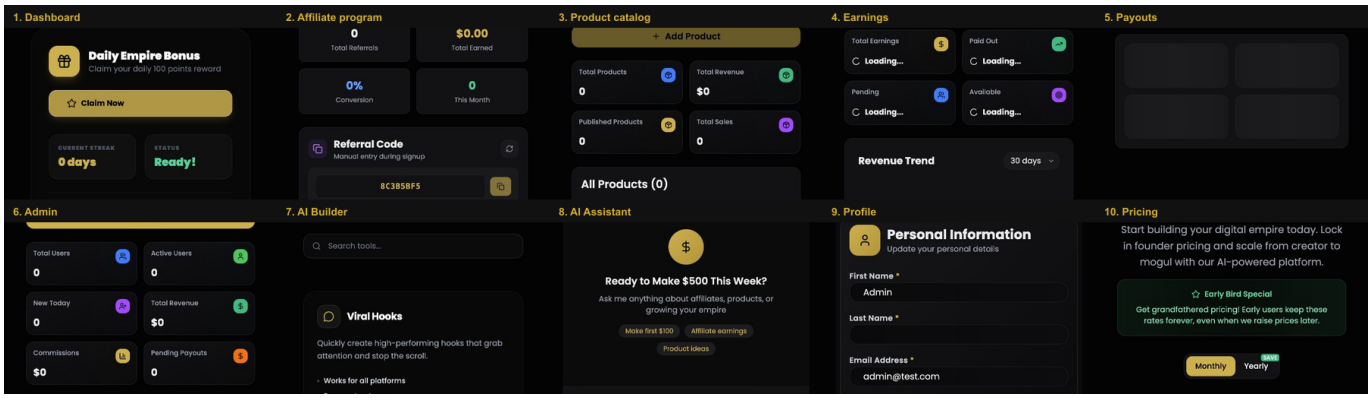
• Make refund, cancellation, approval hold and payout timing visible before an affiliate promotes.

• Give businesses a disclosure template and show affiliates a clear disclosure reminder. The FTC says endorsers must disclose material relationships and should not assume audiences already know about them.

• Get local tax, payout and terms-of-service advice before moving real money for multiple businesses. This report is product strategy, not legal advice.

7. Evidence from the live app review

The contact sheet below shows the authenticated first-view states captured during this audit. The interface is visually cohesive in black and gold, but the routes are oriented around an individual AscndLabs creator/affiliate rather than a paying business operating a program. Several operational screens also showed loading/skeleton states during capture, so resilience and empty-state clarity should be part of the refocus work.



Step	Captured route	General health
1	Dashboard	Visually polished, but gamified and not business-program oriented.
2	Affiliate Program	Core reusable page, but only supports AscndLabs global referrals.
3	Product Catalog	Useful offer foundation; reposition inside a business workspace.
4	Earnings	Useful future affiliate ledger; loading state was visible during capture.
5	Payouts	Useful foundation, but the first viewport remained a skeleton/loading state.
6	Admin	Strong platform-operator base; needs business roles and program scope.
7-8	AI Builder / AI Assistant	Good standalone tools, poor primary-nav fit for this goal.
9-10	Profile / Pricing	Necessary supporting surfaces; pricing copy needs the new B2B offer.

8. Sources and final recommendation

Payment model sources

• Stripe Connect overview: https://docs.stripe.com/connect

• Stripe SaaS platforms vs marketplaces: https://docs.stripe.com/connect/saas-platforms-and-marketplaces

• Stripe Connect charges and funds flow: https://docs.stripe.com/connect/charges

• Stripe marketplace essential tasks: https://docs.stripe.com/connect/marketplace/essential-tasks

Disclosure source

• U.S. FTC, Disclosures 101 for Social Media Influencers:
https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/disclosures-101-social-media-influencers

Final recommendation

Keep the codebase, but stop adding features to the old product. Start a focused “Affiliate Programs” workspace beside the existing app, hide unrelated navigation for business accounts, and personally onboard the first five customers. The first credible milestone is not feature breadth; it is one attributed sale and one explainable commission for each customer.